

NETFLIX REDESIGN

THE PROBLEM:

Users Spend

eighteen minutes

scrolling Netflix before they press play

Netflix shows 200+ titles across 40 rows but never asks what you actually want right now. No mood. No time constraint. No intent. Just an ocean of thumbnails.

 **60-90s**

Users switch or close the gap if they don't find something

--- Netflix CPO- ACM 2016

 **80%**

of all viewing comes from Netflix algorithm but it never asks the user about their real time intent

---New America OTI

 **46%**

Of streamers feel overwhelmed by choices → hit decision fatigue

---Nielsen 2022

"Some people get analysis paralysis."

— Todd Yellin, Netflix VP of Product

"Can't find anything for an hour unless you know exactly what to watch."

— Play Store review, 1★



NETFLIX SYNDROME

The act of spending more time choosing content than actually watching it, now a peer-reviewed academic term.

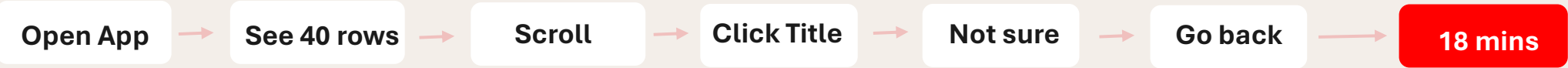
Kim, H. & Choi, J.H. (2024)
Asian Journal for Public Opinion Research
Vol. 13, No. 1, February 2025

THE AUDIT

WHERE IT BREAKS?

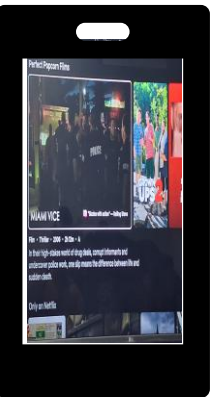
Netflix captures **1,300+ data points** per user including watch history, pause timing, scroll speed, hover duration but never asks **one question** about what you want *right now*.

CURRENT USER FLOW



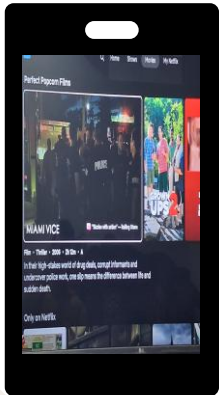
4 BREAK MOMENTS – FROM MY NETFLIX WALKTHROUGH

01 Zero Intent on entry



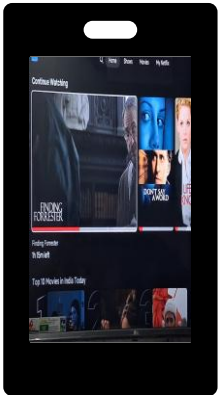
Home screen drops you into a grid of thumbnails. No "what are you in the mood for?" the 90-second abandonment window starts with zero direction.

02 Opaque row logic

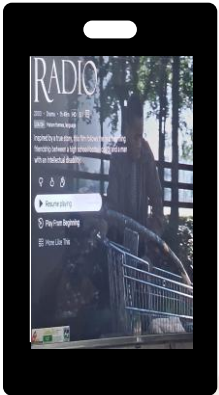


"Perfect Popcorn Films" puts a gritty cop thriller next to a slapstick comedy. The grouping is vibes, not reasoning users can't compare across tones.

03 Shallow recs and no decision support



There is no connection or rational behind recommending a certain movie. No emotional or thematic link is there. Title page shows genre and runtime but not: does this fit your time? Does it match your mood tonight? Why was this picked for you? More options, not better info.



NETFLIX TRIED THIS

In 2021, Netflix launched **"Play Something"** which was a shuffle button to combat decision fatigue. Killed it in **January 2023** due to low usage. Why? No intent capture, no reasoning, no context. Just random picks from your history.

THE REDESIGN LOGIC

THE FIX

What if Netflix asked **one question** before showing you anything?

THE INTENT GAP

WHAT NETFLIX KNOWS TODAY

Watch History

Pause Timing

Scroll Speed

Hover Duration

Genre preferences

Time of day

Device type

Abandonment signals

All of this **backward looking** is inferred from what you did last week, last month, last year. None of it captures what you want right now

WHAT IT SHOULD ALSO ASK



Time

"How much time do you have?"



Mood

"What's the vibe tonight?"



Icon

"Who's watching with you?"

Forward-looking - 3 taps, 10 seconds. Captures what no algorithm can infer: the user's present-moment intent.

THREE DESIGN PRINCIPLES

Intent before inventory

Ask what the user wants before showing everything. Reduce 200 passive options to 5-7 active, reasoned recommendations.

Iyengar & Lepper (2000): reducing choices from 24 to 6 increased purchase rate by 10x.

JPSP, Vol. 79(6)

Show Why

Ask what the user wants before showing everything. Reduce 200 passive options to 5-7 active, reasoned recommendations.

Netflix's own research: users engage significantly more when they understand why something was recommended.

Netflix Tech Blog · New America/OTI 2026

Respect Time constraints

If a user has 45 minutes, don't show 2.5-hour movies. Time is the most basic viewing constraint — every streaming platform ignores it.

Hick's Law: decision time increases with the number and complexity of choices. Fewer relevant options = faster decisions.

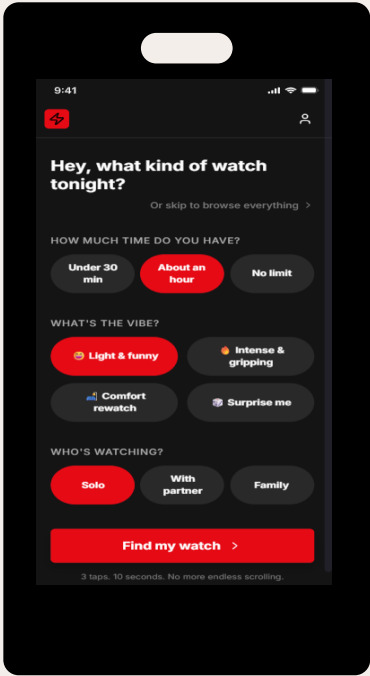
k (1952), QJEP, 4(1)

THE WIREFRAMES

THE REDESIGN

From "what should I watch?" to watching in 3 taps

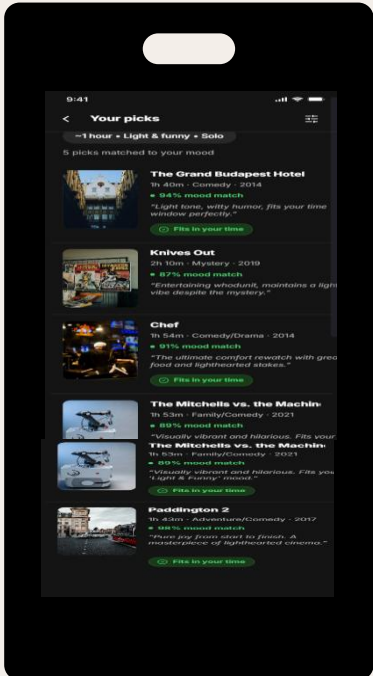
1 Intent Selector



WHY THIS SCREEN

Three taps, not a form. Captures time + mood + social in 10 seconds The three dimensions Netflix's algorithm can never infer from history alone.
Addresses Break #1: zero intent on entry

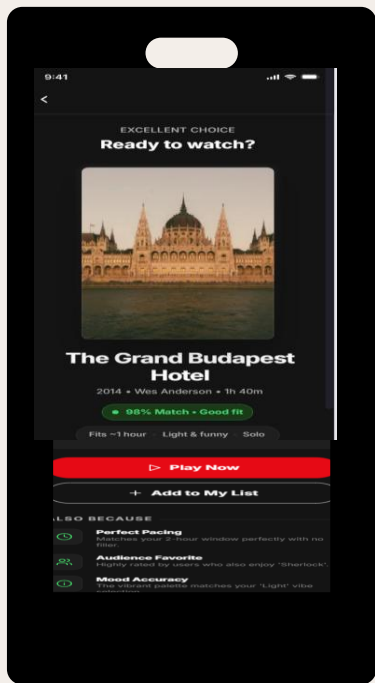
2 Curated Results



WHY THIS SCREEN

5-7 picks, not 200. Each shows match %, mood fit, time fit, and plain-language reasoning. Builds trust through transparency.
Addresses Break #2, #3: opaque logic + shallow recs

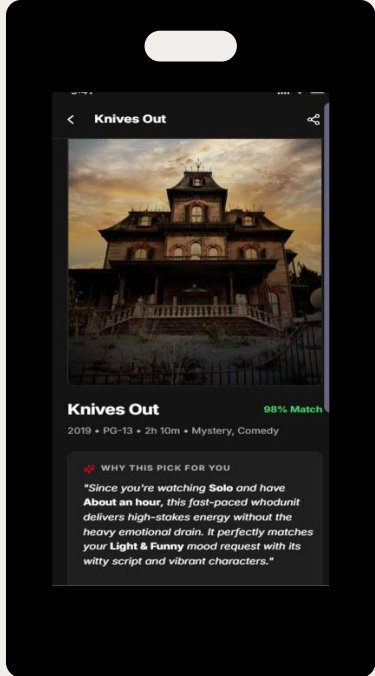
3 Just pick for me



WHY THIS SCREEN

For the "I genuinely don't care" user. One full-screen pick with reasoning. Play or skip — each skip teaches the system. What "Play Something" should have been.
Evolves Netflix's failed 2021 shuffle

4 Post Play feedback



WHY THIS SCREEN

Quick thumbs + "was the mood right?" — closes the feedback loop that current Netflix lacks. Future intent matching improves with every response.
Addresses Break #4: no decision support feedback

THE METRIC

THE PROOF

Every metric is **chosen with reason**, backed with **data**, and defended with **research**.

NORTH STAR

Browse-to-play conversion rate

% of sessions where a user plays something within 2 minutes of opening the app

WHY THIS METRIC

It captures exactly what we're solving. the time between opening Netflix and actually watching. If intent-based browsing works, this is the number that moves first.

~18 min → **<2 min**
current avg target

Why <2 min: Netflix's own ACM paper says the abandonment window is 60-90 sec. If intent is captured in 10 sec and results are shown in 5-7 curated picks, the decision should complete within the safe window.

SUPPORTING METRICS

Avg browse time before play

Time from app open to first play event

Should decrease ↓

Baseline: 18 min avg (SearchLogistics, 2026)
Target: <5 min

Iyengar & Lepper: reducing options from 24 to 6 cut decision time dramatically. We reduce from 200+ to 5-7 — a 30x reduction in choice surface area.

Session abandonment rate

% of sessions ending without any play event

Should decrease ↓

Baseline: est. 20-30% (hypothesis)
Target: <10%

Netflix CPO (ACM 2016): abandonment risk spikes after 60-90 sec. Intent capture resolves direction within that window, keeping users inside the safe zone before frustration hits.

Post-play mood match

% of users who say "mood was spot on" after watching

Should increase ↑

Baseline: no current metric exists
Target: >75% "spot on"

Kim & Choi (AJPOR, 2025): Netflix Syndrome causes stress and "suspension of viewing." Mood-matched content should reduce post-choice regret and improve retention.

HOW TO VALIDATE

A/B test: 10% of users see intent-based flow on app open. Control: standard Netflix home. Treatment: intent selector → curated results. Run **4 weeks**. Segment: new users vs. power users vs. re-engagement. Measure all 4 metrics. After first test, iterate on: number of mood categories (3 vs 6), skip rate on intent selector, optimal result count (5 vs 7 vs 10).

Sources: Netflix ACM TMIS (2016) · SearchLogistics (2026) · Iyengar & Lepper, JPSP (2000) · Kim & Choi, AJPOR (2025) · Nielsen (2022)